

**UROMI JUSTICE DEVELOPMENT PEACE AND CARITAS INITIATIVES
(UROMI JDCPI)**

CORPORATE FACT SHEET

Name	Uromi Justice Development Peace & Caritas Initiatives, (Uromi JDCPI).
Owner	Catholic Diocese of Uromi, Nigeria.
Legal Holder	His Lordship, Most Rev. Dr. Donatus Aimioshor Ogun (OSA)
Authorized Representative & Director	Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Oriabure Arhedo
Corporate Registration No:	CAC/IT/No: 50042 & ED/MWASD/NGOR/200/04
Status	Catholic Non-Governmental, Non-Profit making, Humanitarian and Development Organization.
Motto	Hope for the Oppressed and Empowerment for All
Areas of operation	Integral Development, Human Rights, Democracy, and Good Governance, Alternative Dispute Resolution, Prison Apostolate and Legal Aid services, Peace Building, Micro-Credit and Caritas, TB and HIV/AIDS care and support, HIV Counseling and testing, Livelihood improvement, Anti-Human trafficking and VC programming
Project steered	Conflict Management, Training of Electorate, Election Observation, Budget Monitoring, Community TB Care, HIV/AIDS Awareness Creation & Counseling, Micro-Credit Facilities, Rural Community Development Enlightenment Campaign, Prisoners' Welfare Services, Gender And Child Rights, Widowhood Association, Human Rights, Training Programmes for Police Officers and Youths, Women Development & Promotion through Micro Credit, Emergency Response, Legal Aid, VC Programming, Capacity Strengthening for Good Governance, Campaigns and Sensitizations Against Human Trafficking as well as Creating Alternatives to Human Trafficking through Vocational Skills Acquisition and Empowerment, Human Right Education and Paralegal Scheme and Don't Pay With Your Life
Focus Group	The rural populace, the economically deprived, families, children, students, youths, women and widows living among the poorest of the poor in the society. Inmates in Prison and Ex-inmates, persons stigmatized with deadly diseases.
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Bankers	• UBA BANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • ECOBANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • FIDELITY BANK PLC Mission Road, Uromi • Unity Bank PLC Mission Road Uromi • Union Bank PLC Mission Road Uromi
Staff Strength	13
Number of Community Volunteers	65
Project Executed	16

INTRODUCTION

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives sustained developmental effort across its thematic areas to contribute to peaceful coexistence, better information sharing and improved livelihood in the five Local Government Areas of Edo Central Senatorial District.

In the human rights desk, Uromi JDPCI improved the capacity of Human Rights Club members and Paralegals in 27 communities with training on the Legal system, Judicial procedures and basic legal terms, quarterly meeting for experience sharing and shared learning. This was to strengthen the effort for the development of synergy and mobilization of local resources for effective response to human rights promotion in the selected communities across the five LGAs.

Uromi JDPCI also conducted monitoring to beneficiaries in previous project as well as engaged some of the beneficiaries across the five LGAs in discussion on better parenting with a bid to improve their capacity for improved caregiving which would reduce susceptibility to human trafficking and irregular migration. Uromi JDPCI also engaged in sensitization across communities, schools and church to raise awareness on the danger of human trafficking and irregular migration and promote the need to curb the ugly trend in Edo Central Senatorial District. Parents'-caregivers' dialogue on human trafficking and irregular movement in three LGAs was also facilitated within this period

In the same vein, Uromi JDPCI provided welfare and spiritual support to the inmates in Ubiaja prison through the celebration of New Year with the inmates and the provision of food stuff to them during Easter.

The Micro Credit desk also sustained the empowerment drive with the provision of support to beneficiaries in groups across communities in Edo Central Senatorial District. There is great improvement in the assessment of loan through bank transfer. Although the refund of loan is still manual

QUARTERLY MEETING OF PARALEGALS

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives (Uromi JDPCI) held the fourth quarterly meeting of the Paralegals in the Human Right Education and Paralegal Scheme project on the 13th of March 2020 at the Chancery Complex, Egbele Uromi. The meeting provided a platform to review the activities carried out by the human rights clubs in the last three months, note their challenges and make useful recommendations for improvement. The emphasis at this quarter was on intensifying community sensitization to create awareness and enlighten the people on the need to report violations, especially when it concerns children and women in their community. This is because they were most vulnerable to violations and abuse. Participants at the meeting were 26 females and 37 males making a total of 63 participants which comprised the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI and 4 project Staff, the 5 Supervisors of the Human

Rights Clubs across the Five Local Government Areas of the project intervention as well as the Paralegals of the various human rights clubs in the 27 communities.

The quarterly meeting started by 12:30pm after participants were dully registered and seated, which was followed with the opening prayer led by Bar Mrs E.C Akewe, Supervisor of the human rights clubs in Esan South East Local Government Area.

After that, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, gave the opening remark. He welcomed all participants to the meeting and reiterated the goal of the intervention which includes the promotion of social justice and peaceful coexistence of community members. He reaffirmed that the duties imposed on the paralegals and the human rights club members were voluntary in nature, done for the sake of God with no expectation of human reward or appreciation. He reminded them of the fact that they were the voices to the voiceless who are mostly the poor and economically deprived persons in the society. He



Overview of participants at the meeting

further stated that any act done in this regard must be done with humility, by seeing others better than them according to Apostle Paul in the Bible and shunning all spitefulness or embarrassment.

Furthermore, he pointed out that the fight for human rights was devoid of all religious, ethnic or political affiliations, instead, it was a unanimous call to fight against evil in the society irrespective of culture, creed or race. He enjoined all participants to be transparent, fair and wise in their dealings as well as sustain the motive of the scheme for a better society in the present and future.

At the end of the remark, roll call of the human rights club was done and the under listed clubs had their paralegals present at the meeting; Ewu, Usene, Agua, Akho, Idumebo, Eguare-Ekpoma, Egoro-Amende, Ukpenu, Ukhun, Emuado, Ivue, Efandion, Eror, Egbele, Amendokhian, Idumeka, Igueben, Ewossa, Amahor, Ebelle, Ubijaja, Ewohimi, Emu, Ahia, Okhuesan and Ewatto human rights clubs Thereafter, the human rights clubs were sequentially called upon to present report for the quarter.

Ewu Human Right Club- the Paralegal reported an incident of a 14years old child alleged to have been defiled by a 70 years old man who had the child in his custody. The case was reported to Uromi JDPCI by the parents of the child and a good spirited individual in the community. Uromi JDPCI has since taken up the issue



The Paralegal giving his report

with a report to the Police and the case has been transferred to the Family Unit in the State Headquarters. The Ministry of Justice, FIDA and the Ministry of Social Development and Gender Issues have been sent referral letter to take up the issue of which they have expressed readiness to do so. The Project team monitored the psychological, physiological and emotional well-being of the victim who was admitted in a Hospital (name withheld) as well as the progression of events to ensure that justice was done. Uromi JDPCI also bore the burden of the hospital bill as well as supported the logistics for investigation of the case. The case has been charged to court with the accused remanded at the Ubiaja Correctional Center. In addition to that, the paralegals in seeing the need to safe guard the rights and welfare of children in the community organized and held a community sensitization on human rights and the need to protect children from domestic abuses, harm or dangers.

Usenu Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that they conducted sensitization against child labor particularly child hawking in their community. He noted that the sensitization was necessitated by the high number of children seen engaged in street hawking during school hours. Furthermore, community parents were advised and encouraged to take their out-of-school children off the street to learn skills in varied vocations and training centers so that they will be productive to themselves and their families. The Paralegal also thanked Uromi JDPCI for the intervention on a child' case who was driven out of the house by her grandmother and uncle.



A paralegal giving report at the quarterly meeting

Ekon Bright is a double orphan who lived with her maternal grandmother with her sibling. The child' case was reported to Uromi JDPCI by the school principal who said the child' absent from school for two consecutive weeks prompted her enquiry, and then discovered that the child was sent out of the house. The Paralegal and lawyer were sent to the family on three occasions to accept the child. The family accepted her at a point and sent her out again, but a good spirited individual who found her at the veranda of a church building in the night took her home. On the 24th of December the uncle and her grandmother arrested the woman (helper). Upon our intervention, the Divisional Police Officer (DPO) opted for alternative resolution which he anchored. After he has heard from all the parties and on the final note he asked the child where she would prefer to stay, the child opted to stay with the new caregiver. The DPO affirmed that the resolution must be in the best interest of the child. All the parties accepted that the child should stay where she preferred. Uromi JDPCI thereafter linked the new caregiver to another project for economic empowerment and livelihood support to cater for the child while her educational needs through secondary school also taken by Uromi JDPCI.

Agua Human Right Club -The paralegal reported that sensitization of community elders on Constitutional rights was carried out by the human rights clubs and they resolved some disputes between some individuals in the community through Alternative Dispute Resolution.

Akho Human Right Club- The paralegal reported the members of the club conducted sensitization on Child Abuse and Maltreatment; during which they encouraged community members to treat all children with equality in mind without any form of gender bias.

Idumebo Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that during their club meeting in the month of January, plans were put in place to recruit more persons to the human rights club, which saw to the implementation in February. He added that they have planned to conduct sensitization in schools and communities on human rights in the next quarter.



Idumebo Paralegal giving his report

Eguare-Ekpoma Human Right Club-The paralegal stated that step down training focusing on Constitutional Right and Nigeria Legal System and basic Legal terms was carried out for the members of the human rights club in January and February. Members of the club were also taught how to conduct investigation and the act of reporting. Also, in collaboration with their Human Rights Supervisor, they conducted sensitization in 3 schools; where the students were enlightened on the need to report incidences of rape and any form of sexual harassment, defilement or abuse.

Egoro-Amede Human Right Club-According to the paralegal, community women were sensitized on female disinheritance in January while in February, school sensitization was carried out on rape and finally, in March, community was sensitized on constitutional right, detention, arrest and bail.



A cross section of participants during meeting

Ukpenu Human Right Club- According to the paralegal, the human right club of Ukpenu did not hold any meeting nor carry out any activity in the first quarter of the year due to an observance of a mourning ritual observed by the community over the death of one of the Chiefs in council.

Ukhun Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that in the month of January, church sensitization was carried out on human rights, female disinheritance and Alternative Dispute Resolution. While in the month of February, the same sensitization was done in the community town hall for community members wherein the supervisor for the Local Government was present

and lastly, in March a step down training was done for members of the human right club on the rule of law, separation of power, legal system and affidavit.

Emaudo Human Right Club- Reported that they conducted community sensitization for women on the need to report rape cases so as to deter people from perpetuating it.

Ivye Human Right Club- Reported that school, church and community sensitization on Gender equality and female disinheritance were held with emphasis on the need to allow Women inherit properties of their Father and Spouse. They also assisted to resolve some dispute between two families in the community, to which both parties expressed satisfaction. The Paralegal stated that one of their member who was an opinion leader and a member of the chief in council had passed on. During their human rights meeting in March, they club discussed the need to recruit a new opinion leader into the human rights club.

Error Human Right Club- Reported that they conducted community sensitizations were carried out in January on female inheritance in the month of January. In February, they did another one on rape and importance of sex education and in March, it was on democracy and freedom of speech.



Paralegal giving report

Egbele Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that community sensitization was carried out on the rights of children and equal right of inheritance by male and female children in January and February respectively.

Amendokhian Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that community women were sensitized on issues of rape and female disinheritance in January. While in February, at the human rights meeting, the discussion bothered on inheriting the propriety with community idol or otherwise of female children inheriting a house with a community idol in it. And finally, in March, two schools were sensitized on rape, and human rights enshrined in the 1999 constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria.

Eguare Igueben Human Right Club-They conducted sensitization and assisted two warring parties to resolve their dispute through Alternative Dispute Resolution.

Idumeka Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that the month of January was used to evaluate their performance of the last quarter and measures were suggested to tackle the weakness discovered. While in February, step down training was conducted for



Emu Paralegal giving his report

members on Constitution right and that they have also been involved in community sensitization

Ebelle Human Right Club-The paralegal stated that a step down training on gender issues and female disinheritance was conducted for members of the human right club during their January meeting, whereas in February, church sensitization was held on the rights of children, while in March, another step down training of the human rights club members was carried out on the Nigeria Legal System and Basic Legal Terms.

Ubiaja Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that they conducted sensitization to three secondary schools and introduced human rights club in the 3 schools and have been monitoring the progress of the human rights clubs in the schools. They also sensitized a zone in the community on human rights.

Ewohimi Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that community sensitization was done in 3 communities on Female disinheritance and ill treatment of widows. The women appreciated the campaign and asked for its continuation.

Ewatto Human Right Club-Reported that they conducted community sensitization on women participation in the month of January, while in February, community sensitization on human right was done, and in March, community sensitization on rape was held.



Group photograph with Paralegals and their supervisors

Okhuesan Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that sensitization was held in communities in the month of January, Church sensitization in the month of February and school sensitization in March.

Emu Human Right Club- Reported that they conducted sensitization on rape and encouraged community members to report such issues to appropriate authorities when they occur. They also assisted a Widow to get the man she paid to do a job in her house to do it.

Ahia Human Right Club-The paralegal reported that community sensitization was held on female disinheritance for the women. They were encouraged to take the message to the men who are the policy makers in the community.

After the reports, Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis AREHDO appreciated everyone for the efforts put in. He stated that their good work has made it possible for Uromi JDPCI to intervene in human rights violations experienced in the quarter. He however admonished human right club members who were yet to meet up with their monthly duties to emulate other human right club members whose reports were up to date.

The activities reported by some of the paralegals in this quarter was impressive, since they have been able to create positive impact in both communities and schools by instituting human right clubs in schools and intervening in matters brought before their notice through Alternative Dispute Resolution and referrals of incidents to Uromi JDPCI and other authorities.

TRAINING ON THE LEGAL SYSTEM AND BASIC LEGAL TERMS HELD ON THE 26TH TO 28TH OF FEBRUARY 2020 AT THE CHANCERY HALL, EGELLE –UROMI.

In a bid to continually build the capacity of the Paralegals and Human Rights Advocates for effective response to human rights violations in their communities, Uromi JDPCI conducted a training on the legal system and basic legal terms: such as the rule of law, separation of power, arrest, detention and bail procedures, affidavits, Jurisdiction among others. This was to improve the knowledge and understanding of the Paralegals and Human Rights Defenders in the provision of counselling, technical support and guidance to community members in the pursuit of justice and the prevention of human rights violations. It was also meant to create a better understanding of the legal system and its operations so as to encourage the reporting of violations to the appropriate authorities without the fear of uncertainty. The training was facilitated by Bar. Daniel Akhidenor. The training was attended by 114 participants- 59 males and 55 females which includes; the 5 Human Rights Supervisors, Paralegals and Staff of Uromi JDPCI

The training started with the registration of all participants for the training, thereafter, opening prayer was led by Osas Omozejie Esq, supervisor Igueben LGA.

A team member of Uromi JDPCI welcomed everyone present to the training. He stated the objective of the training to the participants and encouraged all to be attentive so that they would be able to step down the knowledge gained to members of their respective clubs afterwards. The facilitator, Bar. Daniel Akhidenor begun the training with a brief summary of the historical background of the Nigeria Legal System, which according to him, evolved from the English legal system and its evolution now known as common law and the customary law, enforceable both at the superior courts and inferior courts. The superior court according to him, include Supreme courts, Court of Appeal, Customary Court of Appeal, Federal High court, Sharia Court of Appeal, State High Courts and the National Industrial Courts; while the inferior Courts includes customary courts, District courts and Magistrate Courts, furthermore, he listed some special Courts met for specific cases due to the parties involved, such as Juvenile courts in Southern Nigeria and Military Courts for Military members only. He explained that the Courts are distinguished as Inferior and Superior Courts based on the scope and capacity of its jurisdiction.

He made distinction between civil and criminal matters. He stated that civil matters deal with encroachment or violations of individual rights. The person taking a case to court is called a claimant and the person been taken to court is a defendant. In criminal cases, the cases are not

personal, it is usually between the state that is the commissioner of police and the person who committed the crime. Criminal Matters where those offenses enlisted as Criminal offenses, and as such matters of those nature were usually between the State and the accused and most times the causative act (the act giving rise to a cause of action) must be present in an offence before it could be regarded as Criminal act.

He explained the general concept of the Rule of Law and Separation of Power to participants. The rule of law was said to mean the equality of all persons before the Law of the land irrespective of Class, Status and position. In other words, the law is a respecter of no person. Therefore all persons must respect the law. Separation of power on the other hand was given as the division of governmental authorities into the legislative, executive, and the judiciary arm of government. He explained that each of the three arms had their specified duties which cannot be encroached upon by either of them. He said that one of the beauties of the system was the introduction of check and balances to prevent tyranny, monopoly and arbitrary use of power.

The facilitator proceeded to explain arrest to the participants. He noted that Arrest is usually for a little period mostly one day unless there is a justifiable reason to hold a person for longer. He noted that according to the law, Arrest must be made on a surety such as an arrest warrant. In other words the arrest of any person must be by lawful process to face a criminal charge; otherwise it becomes malicious arrest and it can lead to civil action on false imprisonment, malicious prosecution or abuse of process.

He also threw more light on the terms; “detention and bail”; he said that detention meant keeping a person or holding a person in custody or confinement which could be investigation detention, pretrial detention, prevention detention secret detention etc. he explained Bail as permission to leave detention awaiting when you will be called by the court and that it could be on bail of more than one surety. He also said that there were stringent procedures to be followed such as investigating the address of the surety in the event of defendant jumping bail. He however added that there are some instances when person cannot be released on bail which could either be in the interest of the person or in the interest of the state.



Cross section of participants during the training

He went further to explain Affidavit as the voluntary declaration of facts written down and sworn to by the declarant and before an officer authorized to administer Oaths, and which can be done in any situation such as change of name, age declaration, missing documents and other reasons.

Jurisdiction is the restriction of authority of a court to entertain a matter which is strictly Statutory in nature because the law that established a court provides jurisdiction for each court to take each and every matter. Also, jurisdiction of courts determined by the type of cases and monetary value with claims, and as such the law that establishes a Court immediately assigns the extent the Court can handle matters in areas relating to fines, sentences of prison terms, parties and other issues.

A participant asked whether the Police were carried along in the human right program currently ongoing, stating the fact that the police were biased and unconcerned about the victims of human right violation, in that, they exhibit attitudes of corruption which include collecting bribe from the accused for such matter not to be prosecuted. Also he expressed dissatisfaction over the fact that human right activist were very few and most Lawyers do not handle cases of human right violation pro bono therefore making it difficult for poor victims of human right violation to institute matters due to high cost of litigation.

In response, the Facilitator answered in the affirmative. Participants were reminded that Uromi JDPCI at the inception of the program had paid advocacy visits to relevant stakeholders which included officers from Area command, NSDCC, DSS and other security agencies. These security agencies have also participated in programs such as the Commemoration of the World human right day organized by Uromi JDPCI. Secondly the problem sometimes lies with us, if we stop giving bribes and seeking out short cuts, the police will have no option but to stop taking bribes and also, the police station is not the office of the lawyer so he cannot always badge into the station demanding for things. Sometimes, people misinterpret the lawyers, it is good to ask the lawyer questions like what he is doing, he should be able to explain it to his clients.

Dominic OKOJE Esq, further advised the participants to learn and employ the act of Patience in the event of arrest, in that, security agencies cannot legally exceed 24hours of detaining a person without charging such accused to Court, breach of it would amount to the violation of fundamental human right and as such legal action would be instituted against such agency. But where a person cannot exercise patience during arrest, then it gives room to bribing of the security agent which is wrong and a criminal act.



Bar. Akhidenor making a presentation

Another participants asked questions about separation of power and wanted to know if any of the 3 tiers of government is above the other? Why then is the Chief Judge of the nation appointed by the executive arm?

Facilitated answered that ideally no one is superior to the other, though they are separate, they all have to work together. The National Judicial Commission (NJC) is responsible for the appointment of the Chief Judge of a Nigeria. The executive can only suggest candidates.

Some other questions asked and answers given are presented below

QUESTION: Do the police have to show warrant before arresting someone?

ANSWER: Yes. He has to prove he is a police man and authority to arrest

QUESTION: What happens when you are kept in detention for longer than 24 hour, what do you do then?

ANSWER: You take up a case against the police for abuse of power.

QUESTION: What happens to someone who runs away after bail?

ANSWER: Every bail needs a surety to be granted. But if the accused jumps bail the surety will be brought to book.

Human rights clubs were admonished to get themselves introduced to the police in their district to foster collaboration with the police in the discharge of their duties. The Paralegals noted that they need Identity Card to introduce themselves to the police. They were advised not to wait for an Identity Card but take bold steps to introduce themselves and should wear their human rights T- shirts during such visits. Moreover the police and other security agents are already aware of their existence; from their state headquarter to the various divisions at the LGA levels.

Uromi JDPCI legal officer used the opportunity of the training to sensitize the Paralegals and Human Right Advocates on the Hate Speech bill before the National House Assembly. The emphasis was on it implication for freedom of speech and regulation. In her lecture, she stated that Freedom of expression was a fundamental Human Right which underpins most other rights and allows them to flourish, and that it was the cornerstone of democracy since it encourages free exchange of ideas, opinions and information. Hence it was an important human right essential for a democratic society.

Elucidating further, she referenced the **Universal Declaration of Human Rights**, stating that Freedom of expression was the right of every individual to hold opinion without interference and seek, receive, and impart information and idea through any media regardless of frontiers.



The Director, addressing participants at the training

She explained that the hate speech and Social Media bills which was proposed at the National Parliament with harsh penalties of capital punishment and the likes sometimes last year titled, ***National Commission for the Prohibition of Hate Speeches*** and the social media bill of 2019; titled, ***Protection from Internet Falsehoods and Manipulations and Other Related Matters Bill***

2019” were infringement of the freedom of expression constitutionally guaranteed. She stressed that the implication of the bill was quite controversial in nature since what constituted hate speech meant amongst others, any expression that was not in conformity with the desire of the incumbent government or any other individuals in one's neighborhood or life. This has adverse effect on both the Social Media in the discharge of their journalism task of newsgathering, news investigation, news broadcast, news evaluation and the Catholic Church that is by nature prophetic, whose reference are based on the bible truth which would have been suppressed by the laws. It also affects the inability of the average Nigeria who lives in a democratic setting with the natural and legal rights to state his views and speak his mind against or in support of anyone. It was also noted that the penalties of capital punishment and other stringent measures proposed for those who will be guilty of hate speech were not commensurate with the offence committed.

She said that the function of every good government was to protect lives and properties and that the proposal of capital punishment and other harsh measures for the violators of the law against hate speech was destructive in nature instead of it to be corrective and as such a negation of what a good government should stand for. It further noted that the proposed bill was not even a priority in Nigeria, rather bills that addresses issues of dilapidated health infrastructure, collapsed education system, poverty, crimes unemployment, corruption and terrorism in the country were more pressing needs of the nation. She noted that the power of speech, which is an endowment conferred only on man through which he expresses his thoughts, creativity, conceptions, ideologies, imaginations and views either verbally or in writing was one of the principal ways of expressing his human freedom, but notwithstanding the above assertion, man's freedom was not absolute.

She concluded by saying that Man was free but he must not abuse his freedom. Hence, should be considerate and wise in his speeches and actions while remembering the philosophical saying that ‘man is free yet everywhere in chains’.

After the presentation, some participants asked questions in relation to the topic.

QUESTION: Are caricatures also hate speech?

Yes according to the new hate speech bill but it is not supposed to be as it encroaches on our freedom of expression.

QUESTION: What is the difference with this new hate speech bill and the 1981 bill?

ANSWER: It is the same bill that was brought back but it has been eliminated because it stops us from having critical examination of government activities

QUESTION: Why are people emphatic about hate speech bill when we have never had the freedom of expression before in this country?



A participant asking question during training

ANSWER: In an ideal country, we have the freedom in our laws. The hate speech bill was informed by the law against defamation of character. The hate speech bill is not a law, it is just a bill and it will not see the light of day.

After the question and answer session, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI, Very Rev. Fr. Fidelis Arhedo appreciated all participants for maintaining a perfect decorum by being attentive to the presentations and actively participating in the program. He encouraged all participants to continue to keep up the good work and never relent in their struggle to enlighten their community on human right so guaranteed.

The participants expressed appreciation and satisfaction on the knowledge gained nothing that the presentation used real life experiences in illustrations and explaining issues for their understanding. They noted that the presentations were well understood as they were effectively delivered by the facilitators and are better armed with the knowledge requisite to promote human right response in their communities.

COMMUNITY SENSITIZATION ON HUMAN RIGHTS CONDUCTED BY UROMI JDPCI IN THE HUMAN RIGHTS EDUCATION AND PARALEGAL SCHEME PROJECT

Uromi JDPCI engaged the community stakeholders across the 27 communities on intervention in Edo Central Senatorial District. The purpose was to enlighten the community members, improve their knowledge, understanding and consciousness of human rights operations



Sensitization at Obiyon Secondary School

and then encourage their wiliness to report human rights violations in the various communities. This was part of the plan to eradicate ignorance and enhance human right knowledge in the target communities, the project conducted sensitization and awareness creation round the target communities across five Local Government Areas. The sensitization was targeted at the community leaders, Opinion leaders, men and women as well as the youths in the selected communities. Their attention was drawn to the



Sensitization at Egbele community

existence of paralegals and human rights clubs established in their various communities to track and report human rights violation. A total of 2871 persons (1061 male and 1810 female) were reached in the 27 communities visited

The sensitization also discussed some cultural practices that perpetuate gender inequality in the various communities.

Some of the cultural practices discussed were:

Widow inheritance: this has to do with the practice of compelling the wife to marry her deceased husband's sibling, step children or relative at the death of the husband. The Edo State law prohibiting the ill treatment of widows was used during this sensitization, to enlighten the people on the consequences of such practices. They were also told that such acts gender based violence, because no man is compelled to marry his wife's sibling at the death of the wife. It was emphasized that such cultural practices were against human rights because it does not give the widow the freedom to speech, and choice as such it takes away her dignity and leave her as a mere commodity.

Some of the community elders tried to offer explanation on the practice of widow inheritance, its important to the community and the women. They argued that such acts were necessary to keep the widow in the family of the husband, so she can mingle with other community members



Sensitization at Ukhun Community

without fear
of



Sensitization at Okhuesan community

abomination. Another line of argument was that, in the days of old, widow inheritance done to retain the prestige, identity and dignity of a woman in the community, since women were not expected to return to their fathers' houses after marriage. As such if a widow is not inherited then, she remains the wife of a ghost and do not have a name. Neither can she associate with other women in the community, nor participate in any community meeting or social gathering because of the fear of attachment to the ghost(of the deceased husband).

However, many of the participants agreed that such cultural practices were no longer relevant and that the original intention has also been abused, hence some of them were gradually disengaging from it. They added that with this sensitization and the document (Law Prohibiting ill treatment of widows) the project has shared with them, the process of abolishing it will be hastened.

Some of the community elders insisted that it was something they inherited, as such they will hold onto it. Uromi JDPCI reminded them that the law will hold them, if anyone has the courage to report such violations, as the purpose of this sensitization was to save them from the wrath of the law because the cultural practice of widow inheritance is against the law of the state.

Some of the communities also remarked that their elders were already reviewing the practice, such that only women who want to be inherited will be made to do so, while those who do not want it will be allowed to be according to their choice. By implication, they are allowing for freedom, choice and association

Female's Right to Inheritance: the need to allow female children inherit property in their fathers' estate was also put forward. This denial of women's right to inheritance also occurs in the husbands' estate. If the female are consider as children, they have equal rights in their father and husbands' estates. This was also debated by participants in

the various communities. While some think that all children should have equal access to the parents' property irrespective of sex, some think it amounts to waste as most parents community usual sell such property, especially if they are landed property. Because they do not need it as such will not develop them in their fathers' community. They were also reminded that even male children sell such property too, as such an act was not enough reason, because there are many other things that can be useful to the female children outside landed property.

They were encouraged to develop the habit of **will writing**, as this will enable them share their property among all their children and wives. Some of them noted that with the explanation provided, it was quite noble to consider female participation in inheritance of family property since they are all children and even play greater role in the care and support for their parents at old age.



Sensitization at Eguare primary school

communities to sensitize them on the need to report human rights violation so as to be able to curtail it. In most of the schools visited issue of defilement, rape and sexual harassment were discussed. The students were encouraged to report any harassment to the school

School Sensitization: In a bid to extend the human rights sensitization to all areas in the target communities, the Paralegals, human rights club members and the Supervisors visited schools in some



Community sensitization at Efandion community



Legal Officer addressing members at Okhuesan



Sensitization at St John's College Ubiaja

authority, the paralegals and human rights club members in their various communities. They were reminded that unless they report, abusers will continue abusing them, to prevent violation there is the need to report violators. A total of 7 secondary schools were visited for sensitization. A total of 1204 persons (681 female and 523male) were reached

Visit to security Agencies by Human Rights Club Member: human rights club members in Esan West and Esan South East LGAs visited the Divisional Police Headquarter to inform them of their presence in the LGAs and emphasized the need for partnership in the prevention of human rights violation. Those in Esan West went further to visit the Police Area Commander's Office and the Nigeria Security and Civil Defense Corp. This was done to make referral and reporting of violation easy.



Sensitization at Egoro Amede Primary School



Sensitization at Eguare Secondary School, Ekpoma

SUPERVISORY VISITS TO MONTHLY MEETINGS OF THE 27 HUMAN RIGHTS CLUBS IN EDO CENTRAL SENATORIAL DISTRICT

As part of efforts to provide monitoring, mentorship and tracking of the activities of paralegals and human rights advocates as well as their progress and challenges, Uromi JDPCI conducted supervisory visit to the 27 human rights club across the 5 LGAs in Edo Central Senatorial District. This is in recognition of the importance of technical support to the achievement of the goal of the Human Rights Education and Paralegal Scheme project. A total of 150 monthly meetings were supervised within the period of this report. The supervision was done by Uromi



Egoro Amede Human Rights club at monthly meeting

JDPCI project team in collaboration with the LGA Supervisors who coordinate



Ebelle Human Rights club at monthly meeting

their various Local Government Areas

At the various meetings, the members discussed the outcome of the various activities they have embarked upon in the community which include, community sensitizations, school sensitizations and market sensitizations; and in most cases it was realized that the impacts made were positive while in few occasions, there exist, some level of disparities amongst community members on the message of the Human Rights Clubs, which were on gender equality in inheritance, cultural practices, child protection, women inclusion in decision making among others.

Also some Paralegals and human Right Advocates who participated in training conducted step down training for the other members of the human rights club. This was to



Amendokhian Human Rights club at monthly meeting

keep them better



Ivwe Human Rights club at monthly meeting

informed and enlightened on key concepts of Human Rights particularly the ones in tune with the Nigerian Constitution so guaranteed.

More so, cases of Human Rights violations were successfully treated through ADR to the satisfaction of the complainant. At Eguare-Ekpoma, the Human Right Club, successfully handled a case of a minor who was alleged to have been battered by his school teacher, resulting to fracture of the leg; members of the Human Rights Club took up the case, reported to the appropriate authority and the teacher was punished and made to bear the responsibility for the hospital bills. The parent of the child expressed gratitude to the Human Rights club and noted that they were satisfied with the resolution



Ewu Human Rights club members after meeting

The Human Rights

Clubs haven



Ewatto Human Rights club members after meeting

successfully organized monthly meetings, have been able to meet part of the Objectives of the

Human Rights and paralegal Scheme due to the known and recorded impacts made by the various Clubs. It is believed that with more efforts, the Human Rights Clubs would be able to successfully influence the society at large to embrace a more civil way of living, for the growth and development of all persons.

ANTI HUMAN TRAFFICKING DESK

DON'T PAY WITH YOUR LIFE

MONITORING VISIT TO BENEFICIARIES

In the quarter under review, Uromi JDPCI conducted follow up visits to 50 families that benefitted in the PACKING project. The purpose was to ascertain the situation of their business and to find out whether their children were able to continue their education. The findings revealed that over 90% of the beneficiaries still have their business running while about 10% were out of business due to ill health and some of them are still



A beneficiary's shop during visit



A beneficiary attending to a customer during visit

optimistic that they can return to business after they have fully recovered, but few out of the 10% do not think they can return unless they were support with finance. However, all the children supported including those who's caregivers have been out of business are still in school except those who have completed their secondary education but have not been able to pass the required number of subjects to proceed to the tertiary level of education. The caregivers expressed appreciation to the project for the support they received which has improved their livelihood and economic capacity.

FOCUS GROUP DISCUSSION WITH BENEFICIARIES IN EDO CENTRAL SENATORIAL DISTRICT ON 25TH, 26TH AND 28TH OF FEBRUARY 2020.

Uromi JDPCI held a focus group discussion with the caregivers of the selected beneficiaries of the Don't Pay with Your Life project and the caregivers who were empowered under the PACKING project across the five Local Government Areas of the project intervention in Edo Central Senatorial District. The joint meeting provided a platform that brought the beneficiaries together to form a support group that would become the mouth piece and advocates in their various communities to sensitize their fellow caregivers as well as their wards on the ills of human trafficking. The group discussion was focused on the subject of "parenting responsibility"

of which participants were taught who a parent or a caregiver is, the responsibilities that parents or caregivers have towards their children in building a healthy and prosperous community, the things that influences how children are raised and parenting styles. The discussion also looked at how parenting style affect and influence the decision of their children and ward, especially as it concern human trafficking and irregular migration. The discussion which was very participatory; involving role play and brainstorming was facilitated by two of the project staff (Michael Iyoriobhe and Erhabor Harriet). The focus group discussion was held in each of the five Local Government Areas with 100 persons made up of caregivers and project staff in attendance.

The discussion at the respective Local Government Areas commenced with an opening prayer. The program manager; Iyoriobhe Michael welcomed the participants and thanked them for making out time to attend the meeting, especially the PACKING beneficiaries who were previously empowered with grant for Income Generating Activities, thereafter self-introduction was done by the participants.

The project team emphasized that the need for the joint meeting was to allow the potential beneficiaries to get acquainted with those that were previously empowered so that they could become a support group who would join voices to speak against human trafficking in their respective communities and to also promote mentorship in business between the old beneficiaries and the newly selected beneficiaries. It was noted that the group discussion will be held once in every two months for the first six months thereafter it would be once in a quarter. It was also noted that various topics around parenting skills, child development, human trafficking and irregular migration would be discussed. The project team then encouraged all of them to participate actively in the support groups as they will be required to be agents of sensitization in their various communities.

The project team reassured the newly selected beneficiaries of the organization's commitment to providing the support and empowerment to retain their children in school. Stating that the donors have given a go ahead for the commencement of the empowerment and has also made available the funds, hence by April 2020 they would be given the first installment to start their chosen income generating activity and would be closely monitored for a period of six months after which those whose businesses are thriving would be given the 2nd installment. More so, educational support such as direct payment of school fees and school material will be provided for their children by the next session starting September 2020. The Don't Pay with Your Life beneficiaries in the respective Local Government were told that they would be required to sign a contract with Uromi JDPCI before the grant would be disbursed to them. The provisions of the contract were read and explained to them which they assented to. They were told that they would be contacted in three weeks' time to sign the contract after which they would be given the first installment of the grant to commence their chosen income generating activity.

Progressively, the topic of discourse; "parenting responsibility" was introduced. It was reiterated that good parenting was the foundation of having children who would grow up to become

disciplined and successful adults members of the society and such plays a significant role in the fight against human trafficking and irregular migration.

A parent was defined as a person's Father or Mother while a caregiver is a person who provides direct care to children. Parenting on the other hand is the act of raising a child until he/she becomes an adult. It involves meeting the physical, emotional, intellectual, social, protection and spiritual needs of the child. The participants were asked to mention some of the physical needs provided by them to their children and some of the responses that were given include: providing them with food, water, clothes and shelter. They were admonished to develop better understanding of their children, have good interactions with their wards, set limits for them, supervise, guide and discipline them in positive ways. Children should be given reasons why they should not engage in activities that would endanger their lives and guide them rightly in making decisions.

The facilitators emphasized that the attitudes exhibited by children normally reflects the lessons learnt from parents and often times influences the decisions children make in life. Hence, the need for good parenting which requires the taking care of our own children and to care for the good of every child in our community. The participants were told to be attentive to the desires, needs and ideas of their children and not to victimize them in the event where they act contrary to their laid down principles, rather they should correct and chastise them with love and the child must be made to realize the wrong committed, why it is wrong and the benefit of making better choices in the future.

Furthermore, the parents/caregivers were advised not to be too hard or hostile to their children as such disposition would only make a child afraid of his/her parents, seeing them as war lord, instead of a confidant. Thus, they would prefer to discuss issues and seek advice from their peers who many a time gives them wrong advice.

They were told not to pressurize their children to travel overseas through porous routes in search for greener pastures but to encourage and support them to go to school or learn a trade so that they will be able to make a living.

Questions and issues raised in the respective Local Government Areas are summarized below:

ESAN NORTH EAST

One of the beneficiaries asked: What should one do when the parents of a child rebukes an individual for attempting to correct and advise their child.

The facilitator responded that such parents can be approached and made to understand that your intention



Cross session of participants in Esan North East during the focus group discussion

towards the child is of good and that you care about the child's future as much as they do, hence the rationale for correcting and advising the child so as to ensure that he/she follows the right path of living. Stating that all human beings are rational in nature and as such would listen to good reasoning

Another beneficiary in her question, stated that there is a child who leaves home looking decently dressed but out of sight of her parents she pulls her skirt up and looks indecent. She has spoken to the child severally but the child does not heed her advice, what should she do in a situation like this?

She was advised to keep talking to the child in a calm way and be hopeful that the child would desist from such attitude. She should bring the child closer to herself and make her see reasons why she should not act in such a manner.

ESAN CENTRAL

A caregiver said that her grand-daughter in secondary school requested for an android phone and she declined the request because she cannot afford to buy her a phone as paying the grand-child's school fees was more important to her. She thus asked, if it was advisable to buy an expensive phone for a child at the expense of his or her education.

She was told that the child's education was more important than buying her a phone. Such a child should be made to understand why paying her school fees in ensuring she is retained in school is more important than owning a phone at the moment.

A concern was raised by a parent on how to handle the unyielding nature of some children to given instruction.



The facilitators responding to issues raised by participants in Esan Central Local Government Area

In response, the facilitator emphasized that parenting style often influence children's level of obedience to their parents. When a child is taught to be obedient and disciplined from cradle, he or she naturally tends towards being obedient and disciplined as he or she grows older and vice visa. However, in cases of children who had a bad upbringing which has resulted to them being disobedient, caregivers and parents should take it upon themselves to continually correct, advice, pray and guide such children in the right direction until the desired change is seen in the children. They are to help nurture and bring out the good in the children.

ESAN SOUTH EAST

A participant raised a concern that it was difficult for mothers to correct misbehaving adolescents who are not their children, stating that the parents of such



misbehaving adolescent do not appreciate the efforts and most times misconstrue the good intentions of the correctors.

Another participant pointed out that when she attempted to show concern to a secondary school dropout who became a sales girl at the filling station, by enquiring from the child's mother the reason her child dropped out of school, the response she got from the mother was very rude and unfriendly. She then asked how she would continue showing concern to such persons.

Responding to that, the facilitator advised the participants to be diplomatic in handling such issues by avoiding criticism, sarcastic and judgmental approach.

The facilitator addressing participants during the focus group discussion in Esan South East

He said that man in his egocentric nature would like to justify his lapses in the face of condemnation. He advised them to be very friendly in their approach so that parents of such misbehaving children can read their good intention and probably open up to seek solution to their problems.

IGUEBEN

Similar questions were raised by participants at Igueben Local Government Area.

One of the caregivers asked: what if a child is very stubborn and doesn't take advice?

She was told that the child should be corrected with love and not in a manner that will push the child away from them and the child should also be put in prayers.

A participant advised everyone to listen to their children and correct their mindset whenever they were wrong and not to celebrate or support their children in wrong doing.



Project staff addressing beneficiaries at Igueben LGA, Igueben

ESAN WEST

During the discussion, some of the participants noted that not having adequate fund to care for children often times lead children to making hasty decision to travel overseas irregularly in order to make money to improve the livelihood conditions of their families.

The facilitator said that the sponsors of the project intends that caregivers should be able to carter for their children, hence the essence of the project- To eradicate human trafficking by ensuring that children are retained in school and catered for through the empowerment of their caregivers for income generating activities. They were thus encouraged to opt for businesses that can generate



a large income so that the turnover can keep the business going and be able to care for their children.

A participant admonished her fellow parents to have a friendly relationship with their children so that they would be free to open up on private issues that are bothering them as they do with their friends. The focus group discussion was a success as participants were opportune to share their experience(s) with one another for learning.

Project staff addressing beneficiaries at Esan West LGA

SUSTAINABLE MEASURE AGAINST TRAFFICKING IN PERSONS (SMAT-P)

COMMUNITY SENSITISATION

As part of effort to curb human trafficking and irregular migration in selected communities, Uromi JDPCI carried out sensitization on the ills of human trafficking and Irregular Migration in six communities and one church in Esan South East and Esan Central LGAs. The communities and church were: Okpo-Uhomebho-Ewatto, Idinma in Ewatto, Idumigun in Eguare Irrua, Iselu, Idinwe and Izumen communities and then Christ Like Success Ministry, Ewu. The team explained that the aim of the gathering was to enlighten the people on the need for safe migration while discouraging



Sensitization at Idinwe community in Ewatto

human trafficking and irregular migration. It was emphasized that people are often trafficked for exploitation purposes



Sensitization at Idinma Ewatto

thus the team advised that instead of embarking on a journey that would make them to be exploited, they should engage in productive and meaningful activities to have their livelihood improved. A documentary was shown to highlight the dangers of human trafficking and irregular migration to the people and why they should not embark on such trip. A total of 220 persons made up of 89 males and 131 females were reached.

Christ Like Successful Ministries

The church members were on ground and predominantly Esan people in Ewu so an interpreter was needed and they watched with keen interest the Visual of



Members watching the documentary

human trafficking and irregular migration and the team explained



The team speaking to members of the church

the meaning and some causes. Some reactions like “Eya, wetin be this? Oh no, nothing in life”. In attendance were 100 persons comprising of 65 women and 35 men including youths

SCHOOL SENSITISATION



Usugbenu Primary school, Usugbenu, Irrua

Uromi JDPCI carried out sensitization on the ills of human trafficking and Irregular Migration in seven schools: Leaders of Tomorrow School,



Sensitization at Heritage Group of School

Illushi, Irena Secondary School,

Ewatto, Ididigba Primary School, Usugbenu, Heritage Group of School, Irrua, Ewohimi Secondary School, Irena Primary School, Ewatto and Uneah Secondary School, Ibore. The project team emphasized the aim of the visit which was to enlighten the students on the need for safe migration while discouraging human trafficking and irregular migration. It was emphasized



Sensitization at Ewohimi Secondary school

that people are often trafficked for exploitation purposes thus the team advised that instead of embarking on a journey that would lead them into exploitation, they should engage in productive and meaningful activities to have their livelihood



Irena Secondary school Ewatto

improved. A documentary was shown to highlight the students on the dangers of human trafficking to the people and why they should not embark on such trip. A total of 592 students made up of 295 male and 297 female were reached

ANTI HUMAN TRAFFICKING CLUB MEETING

Anti- human trafficking club meeting were held at Annunciation Catholic College, Irrua (ACCI) and Irrua Girls Secondary School.

The team from Uromi JDPCI arrived ACCI at 10am and the students were already seated waiting for the team. The President of the club told the team that during their previous meeting, they discussed the implication of human trafficking. The team admonished the club members to be more vigilant and be ready to always sensitize their peers at home and in

Discussion in Anti Human Trafficking Club



communities. They were also to assist in discouraging internal trafficking in their homes and communities. The president also mentioned that one of the club members by the name Okosun



Group photograph with members of the Anti-human right club in ACC

said he met a boy who was planning to travel abroad irregularly and he made attempts to dissuade him from embarking on such journey but the boy already had his mind made up and was looking for money to pay the woman who would take him abroad. The team advised Okosun to sensitize the boy more on the dangers inherent in human trafficking and irregular migration and try to get the necessary information about the

woman across to the team so that she could be reported to NAPTIP. The team told the club members that the next meeting will take place in the month of June and encouraged members to sustain the club even after the project closes out.

In Irrua Girls Secondary School, the project team encouraged the students to keep speaking on the dangers of human trafficking to their peers at school and in the communities where they live. The need to discourage



The team addressing members of the club at Irrua Secondary School.



The team addressing members of the club at Irrua Secondary School.

internal trafficking was emphasized as many children who have been trafficked internally fall prey to rape and defilement by their supposed guardians. The team said it almost would look like a work not done if students who hear about human trafficking are still molested. A member of the club noted that students in the school are being sensitized continuously by members of the clubs and as such, some students come to seek advice from the president or any of the club member on issues such as if they should live with someone they do not know of which they were told not to follow any person they do not really know to avoid be exploited.

At Agadaga secondary School, Ewohimi where the anti human trafficking team from Uromi JDPCI had a meeting with members of the club, the president of the club gave a detailed report of the activities the club has carried out which includes: School debate where prizes were given to winners, sharing of club members into groups with topics assigned to each, to go and research and make presentation on the topics. The topics shared amongst the groups



Club members chanting the newly composed anthem

are: A time ruined, is a time not gained, the right of a child. Also, the members sang a melodious anthem which they composed for the Anti human trafficking club

In Uhomebho Secondary School where Uromi JDPCI also has anti human trafficking Club, the meeting started with an opening prayer led by the president. He reminded members of the purpose for which the club exist: creating awareness on the dangers of human trafficking and also exposing perpetrators. Staff of Uromi JDPCI present at the meeting encouraged them to



The club president addressing members

come up with activities like debates, Quizz they can get staff of the school and other students involved.

The president on behalf of the other members humbly requested that, the SMAT-P project should help them in producing leaflets, stickers to give out to other students and



Members of the club during meeting

community members.

VICTIM SUPPORT GROUP

The Victim support group meeting began with a review of previous meeting's discussion after which members of the Great Esan Returnees; a group made of Esan indigenes who made their ways out of Nigeria especially through irregular means and returned either voluntarily or through repatriation were introduced and welcomed to the meeting. The President Mr Brown Okojie, Secretary Prince Eugene, and three other members from the Great Esan Returnees advised the returnees in Irrua on the need to make up their minds and be determined to help people to stop human trafficking. They encouraged their colleagues to strive for self-help by first developing themselves and advancing the skills that they have as no external help can make them happier than what they can achieve on their own. The president emphasized the need for synergy and cooperation in their everyday life. Noting that there is no limit to acquiring skills and that as a body they have come to stay so as to continually advance the course of their members in political social and economic sectors. He highlighted some of the support that the group has been able to influence to their members through their interface with government and non-governmental agencies. He further added that new members will still have opportunity to benefit from such support in the future so as to alleviate the plight of returnees as it concern their reintegration. The secretary thereafter collected their phone numbers so as to add them to the Great Esan Returnees WhatsApp platform prompt and easy access to information.

He appreciated Uromi JDPCI and the SMAT-P project that has assisted to established support groups in other part of Esan Land and has asked them to bring the new groups into their folds hence they have come to discuss with them.



President of Great Esan Returnees speaking to members

The Irrua returnees appreciated the team from JDPCI for facilitating the visit from Great Esan Returnees to their meeting and also thanked Mr Okojie and his Executives for the information shared with them as well as accepting them into the general body.



Group photograph of members after meeting

In attendance were 10 members all males and four executive from the Esan Returnees

PARENTS-CAREGIVERS DIALOGUE SESSION ON HUMAN TRAFFICKING AND IRREGULAR MOVEMENT ORGANIZED BY UROMI JDPCI IN COLLABORATION WITH UNHCR's TELLING THE REAL STORY

Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiative (Uromi JDPCI) in partnership with the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees (UNHCR); Telling the Real Story project conducted a parent-caregiver dialogue session on human trafficking and Irregular Movement in three Local Government Areas, namely; Igueben, Esan Central and Esan West on the 17th, 18th and 19th of March 2020, respectively. The meeting was aimed at equipping parents and caregivers in the target



Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo during his opening remarks in Igueben

areas with the right information on the menace of human trafficking and the reasons they should desist from permitting and encouraging the trafficking of their wards. Thus, the Participants who comprised of High Chiefs, Head of Religious Associations, Pastors, School teachers, Principals and parents were shown video clips of the ordeals of the victims of human trafficking, using the testimonies of survivors to speak to caregivers-parents on the issue of human trafficking and irregular movement. The sessions were facilitated by the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI; Very Rev. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo, Michael Iyoriobhe; the Program Manager of Uromi JDPCI and Unyime Johnson; Associate Project Officer of the UNHCR Telling the Real Story project and were very participatory with varied responses, comments and contributions from participants in the respective L.G.As. A total of 171 persons- 94 females and 77 males were reached across the three Local Government Areas.

In the Opening remark, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI; Very Rev. Fr. Dr. Fidelis Arhedo applauded participants for honouring the invitation and said he was elated in coming around to discuss issues of human trafficking with the people and emphasized that the Enojie have been strong bone behind his intervention as JDPC Director in Uromi Diocese.



A cross section of participants in Ekpoma Esan West LGA

He expressed gratitude and noted that it was privilege to have “Telling the Real Story” in our domain, a project

which the UNHCR has been undertaking for past two years in Edo State with the mission to tell the real story of human trafficking and Irregular Migration. He explained human trafficking by looking at three segments- the act, the means and the purpose. Oftentimes, he said people are told unrealistic stories of abroad full of good ideologies and good opportunities. Thus, many people are being deceived and coerced to travel through pressure from parents and peer groups. He noted that the team was not against travelling overseas, as all humans are migrants, moving from one destination to another for different purposes. But if people must travel abroad, they should follow the right way and not involving in unguided and unaided migration through the desert and seas endangering their lives and future. He stressed that the government has failed its citizenry by not providing job opportunities for young people and creating enabling environment for the people to flourish, however the present government of Edo State is working tirelessly to empower young persons in a bid to curb human trafficking and irregular migration. He reiterated that we cannot continue to watch our children being trafficked or moving out on their own to Europe through dangerous terrains where they are enslaved. Hence the gathering together of parent/caregivers to talk and dialogue on the issue of human trafficking and irregular movement from the perspective of the caregivers/parents in Igueben; looking at what we can do to address this global malady and how we can create hope for our younger generation to believe in Nigeria. He therefore indulged participants to contribute to the discussion.

Progressively, an overview of Telling the Real Story project was given by Unyime Johnson; UNHCR representative on telling the real story project. She welcomed participants and explained that Telling the Real Story (TRS) is a project that began in 2016 in countries like Somalia, Sudan and Eritrea where it was observed that young persons were moving outside their countries; as most of them were victims of war

A cross section of participants in Irrua, Esan Central LGA

and others were refugees. Hence they decided to cross over to Europe; but were not doing it in the right way. TRS coming into Nigeria was necessitated

through the 2017 CNN report that talked about what Nigerians and other Africans were facing in Libya and thus in 2018, TRS came on board in Nigeria and was extended to Edo State in particular. Telling the Real Story is all about informing our young boys and girls on the dangers of Irregular movement and human trafficking, reaching out to parents and telling them that they should not push their children out to human traffickers because of the dangers it possess on their wards. She stressed that the project is not saying that we should not encourage our children to move, but its saying that people should migrate the right way. Rather than make themselves subjected to trafficking in midway to Europe, they should identify their purpose of travelling from the beginning, organise for their regular travel using the right modalities by getting their passport, visas and other supporting documents. She reiterated that a lot of people even graduates have been deceived to migrate with the promise of getting jobs in Europe which often proved false. Thus, if our children must travel for job purposes, such jobs must have been advertised, then they will apply, interviewed for it and called to resume. She warned that nothing good comes easy and when a story appears too good, it could actually be false.



Participants watching the video screening with keen interest in Igueben LGA

Immediately after the overview, the participants watched video screening of survivors of human trafficking telling the real story of their journey to Europe and their experiences and ordeals.

In the video, the Survivors narrated how they were introduced to human traffickers by their friends and relatives and deceived that they were going to do legal jobs abroad. But on getting to Libya, their traffickers changed towards them and some of them were sold out and forced to work in brothels; sleeping with different men. Others were forced into prostitution by their traffickers who had earlier promised that they would do decent jobs in Europe which were all lies. They could not say no, because they threatened them with guns, flogged and starved them. They had nowhere to run to because of the terrain of the place and so they kept working as sex slaves. Some of them got infected with diseases and got pregnant in the process. Later on, they were put in an over-crowded rubber boat and taken to Europe through the Mediterranean Sea where some lost their lives. They were eventually rescued and taken to refugee camps by the Italian government but their traffickers helped them to escape from the camps. Their situation became worse when they left camp to meet their Madams who took them to the streets to prostitute and they remitted the money made to them while they lived in debt bondage because their traffickers insisted that they pay every dime they spent in taking them overseas, a debt they could not



Group photograph with Participants at Igueben Local Government Area

finish paying. Some narrated that prior to their journey, they were taken to shrines where they swore oaths with their bodies, hence lived in perpetual fear that the oath will work against them if they refuse to do the bidding of their madams. Most of them prostituted over a year and were exploited in

different ways which got them frustrated and devastated and then, they decided to run away from their madams. However, the aftermath of the prostitution, still linger, as many are still living in nightmares of their experiences, some went insane and others faced with psychological traumas, having bad dreams and the likes. One common fear they all complained about; was fear that their traffickers will bring harm to their parents and siblings at home.

The Survivors said they would never want anyone to experience what they went through and if they had known they would never have left Nigeria.

The Participants with keen interest watched and listened to the experiences of these survivors and expressed great pity and heartbreak on the ordeal faced by their children. At the end of the video screening, the dialogue session was taken where participants were asked questions of which they gave responses, made comments as well as contributions.

After the dialogue session, Very Rev. Fr. Fidelis Arhedo appreciated participants for their comments and responses. Then after, he talked on parental value, emphasizing that the older generation valued children more than anything else, but the society today, practice the contrary, as parents and caregivers no longer place value on their children. He recalled some cultural names



Group photograph with Participants at Esan Central Local Government Area

with deep meaning that connote value for children; names such as **Omonefe**, meaning a child is greater than wealth and riches, **Omoafeba**, meaning wealth is only an addendum to a child, in other words wealth is useless without children, **Omonigho**, a child is greater than money. He urged Participants to make a difference in their communities by valuing their children, guiding them rightly and not pressurizing them to go out and make money like their fellow peers whose source of wealth cannot be traced to any legal venture. He emphasized that **Onoromonduhomo Obhawo** (meaning parent who sacrificed his child for any reason cannot boast of being strong or noble) because **Omo'aluna** (meaning it is your child you labour for) He stressed that parents should not support their children in bad things like enrolling them in Miracle centres to write examinations unknowing to them that they are sowing seeds of Fraud in the children. He advised that the good values of the society should be upheld. Children should be supported in their educational endeavours and be made to have a sense of relevance in the home as research had shown that most young girls from families where the females are been marginalised, migrated irregularly to make money abroad so that they could become relevant and respected in their homes.



Group photograph with participants at Esan Central Local Government Area

the expression of Late Arch-Bishop Benson Idahosa; that there is no height that cannot be reached, but requires treading on the path of hardwork and dedication.

In conclusion, Very Rev. Fr. Fidelis Arhedo encouraged men and women to work-hard to help and uplift their families and admonished the Chiefs to fight and uphold the truth at all times.

MICRO CREDIT

Empowerment of the less privileged in the society has always been one of the major policy thrust of Uromi JDPCI. For this reason the Micro credit scheme was established to provide soft loans for enterprise development. These soft loans are given to groups as well as registered cooperative societies who are into active economic activities. Each group consists of poor, active women and active farmers in the society. This scheme is open to Catholics and Non-Catholics within the Diocese of Uromi. The scheme is currently supporting a total of 1110 persons in all the five Local Government Areas covered by the Catholic Diocese of Uromi.

Chief Irabor, M.O; the Oliha of Igueben Kingdom and representative of the Onojie of Igueben admonished participants to take the message they have heard to their various quarters and encouraged Parents to care for their children so that they will be able to fulfil their destiny. He prayed the ground to swallow anyone who wishes to continue human trafficking in Igueben Kingdom and also prayed against ritualist and their activities in Igueben. He recalled



A beneficiary's shop during mentorship visit

The scheme is in four (4) platforms namely: Group Micro-Credit, PROMIC I, PROMIC II and AGRIC PROMIC (for farmers only). It is a basic requirement that beneficiaries form themselves into self-selected group before they are considered for assessment and training. Upon successful registration, validation and documentations, the members of the group then qualify to get soft loan which must be disbursed to them through their bank accounts.

The Agricultural scheme was introduced to enhance the production and livelihood opportunity of the farmers. The scheme is designed to address the plight of the rural farmers to help increase their



Cross section of micro credit officer and beneficiaries during collection



Cross section of micro credit officers and beneficiaries during formation

agricultural productivity and also for active farmers who wish to move from subsistence farming to small scale commercial farming.

In this quarter a total of 7 groups with 69 members were supported to improve their businesses including farming business across communities in Edo Central Senatorial District. Monitoring visits to the various groups showed that the beneficiaries have gainfully invested their soft loans in their businesses and farms in line with the objectives of the scheme

Uromi JDPCI appreciated the various groups for their solidarity and urged them to co-operate with the organization and show more commitment to repayment that could possibly qualify them for another round of loan. The various groups led by their group leaders thanked Uromi JDPCI for their support and promised to improve on their members' commitment, and pleaded for increase of the soft loan as things were becoming very expensive.

PRISON APOSTOLATE

It was a moment of excitement as the family of Engr and Lady John Amedu KSJI in collaboration with Uromi Justice Development Peace and Caritas Initiatives visited the inmates in Ubiaja Correctional Center to celebrate the New Year with them. The event which took place on the 23rd of January 2020, had the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI Very Rev Fr Dr. Fidelis Arhedo and the staff of Uromi JDPCI in attendance while the inmates who were full of excitement sang melodious songs to praise God.

In his homily, the Executive Director of Uromi JDPCI Very Rev Fr Dr. Fidelis Arhedo who celebrated the mass admonished the inmates and all who accompanied the celebrant to imbibe the virtue of patience as God will always honour his chosen ones. He reminded them that nothing good comes easy but with dependence on God who is the source of creation, good things will fall in place for us. He then enjoined the inmates to be focus in their genuine engagement as they strive to abandon their old ways.

At the end of the mass Engr Amedu appreciated the inmates and officials for allowing the mass take place with decorum as well as attending the mass. He advised the inmates to be patient and work hard when the freedom they desire comes; he advised them to depend on God alone to facilitate freedom.



Very Rev Fr Dr Fidelis Arhedo during homily

In appreciation the Prison welfare officer thanked the family for coming to celebrate with the inmates. Uromi JDPCI thereafter use the occasion to collect request from some of the inmates for possible assistant

Medical Assistance for Inmate in Prison

As a follow up to the requests collected from the inmates Uromi JDPCI visited one of the inmate to ascertain the health condition of the inmate who had malaria (according to medical diagnosis). Uromi JDPCI assisted him with the procurement of the prescribed drugs. Another inmate who was hospitalized was also assisted with the part payment of hospital bill to effect his discharge from the hospital.



Assessing hospital bill for an inmate

Easter Gift to Inmates in Ubiaja Correctional Center

Uromi JDPCI facilitated the delivery of food items from the Catholic Diocese of Uromi to the Correctional Center for the use of inmates. The food items were made up of 5 bags of garri, small bow of onions about 50 tubers of yam and some bunches of plantain. One of the officer who received the items on behalf of the welfare officer expressed appreciation to the Bishop and the entire Catholic Diocese of Uromi for the gift sent to them despite the difficult times created by the COVID 19 pandemic, leaving the world in uncertainty.